

THE INNOVATION AMBITION

The road ahead for Lupin is the most ambitious and the least certain. Both Nilesh and Vinita are clear that the company's long-term goal is to move beyond generics, even complex ones, towards proprietary medicines, branded products and genuine innovation.

"How do you create those capabilities? Those are the kinds of questions that help you take the story forward, not just to be another

bility, the regulatory infrastructure and the commercial model to launch proprietary drugs in regulated markets is a different order of challenge from manufacturing generics efficiently.

But Lupin is approaching it as a long-term investment rather than a leap. The biosimilar pipeline, which requires clinical trial expertise and regulatory sophistication, is pushing the company towards practices closer to innovation. The VISUfarma acquisition gives it a branded

used to treat a form of age-related vision loss where abnormal blood vessels leak fluid into the back of the eye causing sight to deteriorate, in the US by FY27. Aflibercept, which treats similar eye conditions and is also used for diabetic patients where high blood sugar damages blood vessels in the retina, and Etanercept, a drug for rheumatoid arthritis and other conditions where the immune system mistakenly attacks the body's own joints and tissues, are expected to follow by FY29-30.

Each of these is a high-value, technically demanding product in markets where biosimilar competition is still limited. If it executes on schedule, it would represent a meaningful commercial step beyond the generics model.

The broader context for Indian pharma is shifting. Anti-obesity medicines (GLP-1), a class of drugs originally developed for diabetes that have shown dramatic results in weight loss and are now the most talked-about drug category in the world, have created one of the largest new treatment categories in decades. Lupin has moved beyond evaluation. In December 2025, it signed an exclusive licensing agreement with Gan & Lee Pharmaceuticals for a novel GLP-1 receptor agonist as patent expirations on branded drugs begin to open the market to generics and biosimilars.

On mergers and acquisitions, the firm has indicated that it is open to bolt-on deals that accelerate capability building in priority areas, rather than large transformative buys. The ophthalmology deal in Europe is the most recent example of that approach, targeted, capability-focused, and designed to give Lupin a platform to build from rather than a finished business to run. "Pharmaceuticals will remain our core,"

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er success story, but to make a real difference," Nilesh says.

He is under no illusion about what the transition demands. "Each of the evolutions we have gone through, from being an Indian company to a global generics company, from a global generics company to a complex generics company, and now towards becoming an innovation company, each of them had its trials and tribulations."

It is a candid acknowledgement of how hard the transition is. Indian pharma has been attempting to move from generics to innovation for two decades, and the results across the sector have been mixed. Building the clinical trial capa-

foothold in the European eye care segment, where pricing is durable. The respiratory franchise, built over a decade, demonstrates that Lupin can compete in segments that demand more than manufacturing efficiency.

Not everyone is cautious. Axis Securities analyst Aman Goyal says Lupin is "building a durable growth engine," pointing to "22 sole first-to-file exclusivities" and a biosimilars road map that "provides sustained pipeline visibility and margin-accretive growth."

The biosimilar road map is the most concrete expression of that ambition. Lupin is targeting the launch of Ranibizumab, an eye drug